

1954 United Front Election and Demands for Autonomy

Formation of United Front

- ♦ The founding of Awami Muslim League as a new party on June 1949 with Moulana Bhashani as President, Shamsul Haq as General Secretary and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as Joint Secretary is a significant event in politics of East Pakistan. It was born as a protest movement against West Pakistani domination.
- ♦ It was formed with the support of workers and followers of pre-partition Suhrawardy-Hashim group of Muslim League who were considered progressive and people oriented. Suhrawardy after his final return from India became the Convenor of All Pakistan Committee of the Party.
- ♦ The party drew its support from middle class as well as from common masses. Because of its regional base and bias, it soon became a champion of East Bengal's rights and interests. Its popularity was also consistently increasing. On the other hand, being a party of businessmen and landlords and for its anti-Bengali stance, Muslim League was losing its popularity.

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- ◆ The language movement of 1952 caused tremendous upsurge of support for parties like Awami Muslim League as its struggle was for the rights and interests of the mass people of the East Bengal. In this political situation, the long-awaited provincial election was scheduled to be held on 1954.
- ◆ To strengthen opposition and to fight against East Bengal Muslim League, a number of parties formed the United Front in December 1953. Led by Awami Muslim League, the parties that formed the United Front were Awami Muslim League, Krishak Sramik Party led by AK Fazlul Haq, Ganatantrik Dal, a left leaning party led by Haji Danesh, Nizam-e- Islam and Khelafat-a-Rabbani party of Abul Hashim.

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- ❖ Despite ideological differences, this broad alliance was formed on two common grounds: opposition to the Muslim League and West Pakistani domination.
- ❖ In order to maximize support, UF adopted a broad election manifesto with a 21-point program.

1954. The United Front adopted a 21-Point election programme¹⁰ which may be broadly classified under three heads—political, cultural and economic. (i) The political programme demanded full regional autonomy for East Bengal on the basis of Lahore Resolution of 1940, leaving only three subjects, i.e., defence, foreign affairs and currency in the hands of the federal government, transfer of Naval Headquarters from West Pakistan to East Bengal, establishment of an armaments factory in East Bengal to enable it to defend itself against any external attack, separation of executive and judicial functions, repeal of all Security Acts and other repressive laws, release of all political prisoners, and safeguarding of fundamental rights. (ii) The cultural programme included recognition of Bangla as one of the national languages, introduction of Bangla as a medium of instruction in all educational institutions, ensuring autonomy of universities, erection of a memorial for

language movement martyrs of 1952, and declaration of 21 February as a National Day. (iii) The economic programme included guaranteeing basic social and economic rights for industrial workers, nationalisation of jute and fair price for jute-growers, construction of irrigation facilities for food production and famine control, and reduction of disparity in income between high and low-salaried employees.

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- ◆ In short, the 21-point program advocated a more broadly distributive public policy, an expanded role for East Bengal in national affairs and full regional autonomy.
- ◆ **Election campaign:** Election strategy of United Front was to focus on the failure of Muslim League's administration in various fields, especially on the language issue, economic mismanagement, discriminatory policy against Bengalis and food crisis. Negative role of Nazimuddin and Nurul Amin as Chief Minister came under fire.
- ◆ UF's campaigning on language issue and autonomy had great impact on the voters. Various factions of the party who were more aggressive, persuasive and enthusiastic participated in the campaign.
- ◆ **Election:** The election for East Bengal Legislative Assembly was held between 8 to 12 March 1954 on the basis of universal adult franchise but under the principle of separate electorate.

Election Result

- ◆ The elections resulted in a landslide victory for the United Front which won 228 seats in a House of 309 (including nine reserved seats for women). On the other hand, the Muslim League, the party in power managed to get only 7 seats. Of the total, 228 seats elected Front members, 143 belonged to Awami Muslim League, 48 to Krishak Sramaik Party, 22 to Nezam-e-Islam, 13 to Ganatantri Dal and 2 to Khilafat-e-Rabbani Party. Of the non-Muslim seats, Congress got 25, Scheduled Caste Federation 27, and the United Front of the Minorities 13. Chief Minister Nurul Amin was also defeated.

Factors contributing to defeat of ML

- ◆ 1) Muslim League's unqualified support for Urdu as the only state language of Pakistan to the detriment of Bengali interests.
- ◆ 2) Opposition to full provincial autonomy of East Pakistan,
- ◆ 3) Police firing of 1952 against language movement activists and repressive policy pursued against political opposition.
- ◆ 4) Economic distress of people arising out of abnormal price hike of daily necessities including low price of raw jute.
- ◆ 5) Organizational weaknesses including loss of touch with the people.
- ◆ 6) Failure to adopt comprehensive political, social and economic agenda to meet the hopes and aspiration of the people of East Bengal,
- ◆ 7) Growing perception among people about ML govt pursuing a discriminatory and anti Bengali agenda.
- ◆ Added to this major factors are many other minor factors.

Formation of Cabinet and the aftermath

- ◆ The United Front's victory proved illusory long before the euphoria wore out. On March 25, East Pakistan governor Choudhury Khaliquzzaman asked Krishak Sramik Party leader AK Fazlul Huq to form the ministry. But in the ministry formed on 3 April, the Awami Muslim League was left out.
- ◆ This created a crisis in the Front and Fazlul Huq was obliged to expand his cabinet on May 15 to include Abul Mansur Ahmed, Aatur Rahman Khan, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, Abdus Salam Khan and Hashimuddin.
- ◆ The same day, a serious riot between the Bangali and non-Bangali workers of the Adamjee Jute Mills at Narayanganj caused the death of nearly 1500 workers. The communist activists were held responsible for the tragedy, and the Fazlul Huq government was blamed for its failure in controlling the situation. On May 30, the ministry was dismissed and direct governor's rule was imposed.
- ◆ Around 1600 Front leaders and workers, including 30 members of the legislature, were put behind the bars. The Awami Muslim League, however, returned to power on its own on 30 August 1956 with Aatur Rahman Khan as chief minister, but only to resign a few months later.

Cabinet members of United Front with Chief Minister Sher-E-Bangla A K Fazlul Haq

